Out of site

People's protests are meant to be seen and heard, not hidden away

The Delhi Police's decision to denotify Jantar Mantar in the national capital as a site where protests can be organised has itself triggered a storm of protest over its sheer arbitrariness. The Delhi Police, which is under the Union Home Ministry, have told the Delhi High Court that Jantar Mantar was denotified as a protest site following a Supreme Court directive issued on October 9. The Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant had urged the Union government to identify an alternative protest site that is spacious and open. The order was passed while hearing petitions challenging the government's decision to restrict movement within and into the city to halt the October 10 protests demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. Observations were also exchanged that protests in and around Jantar Mantar were a source of inconvenience for ordinary commuters. It is possible to argue that protesters cause traffic congestion and inconvenience. But those arguments are valid only as much as similar arguments that are usually raised against democracy itself. There is a reactionary view that democracy delays decision-making, elections disrupt development and economic activity, and that there should therefore be fewer elections and less politics. The BJP's push for simultaneous elections to Parliament and State Assemblies once every five years is based on the same logic, that at its heart questions the legitimacy of democracy itself. The argument against protests at Jantar Mantar does not hold water. It is antithetical to the concept of public deliberation and protest, which are central to democracy.

A centrally located site of protest is part of the urban space in most democracies, as in Washington DC and London. Public protesters are usually marginal groups who lack representation at the decision-making table. Street protest is actually an outcome of their lack of power, and an instrument for people with no other way of being heard. To keep them far away from the seat of power and render them invisible is a violent police argument against their very attempt to be heard and seen. The reason why a protester wants to be in Jantar Mantar is its proximity to the centre of power – it is located close to the Parliament complex, and the President's Estate. If, in the name of public order, they are pushed far away into the margins of the city, as is now being sought, it is equivalent to keeping them trapped in the very situation they are trying to escape. If protests can happen only far away from the seat of power, the logic can easily be extended to argue that people must stay at home and protest. That is not how a democracy works.

Double standards

The U.S. must stop moralising to the Global South for trading with Russia

Last year, U.S. President Donald Trump imposed an additional 25% tariff on India over India's oil purchases from Russia. Peter Navarro, Mr. Trump's trade czar, even called Russia's invasion of Ukraine "Modi's war", saying India was funding the Russian aggression through energy deals. Last month, Mr. Trump signed the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act into law, giving him the power to impose up to 100% tariffs on countries buying Russian energy, including India and China. And then, last week, Mr. Trump announced a deal to buy Russian diesel – releasing 300,000 tonnes immediately to the "American and global marketplace" followed by 5,00,000 tonnes in November. Immediately after the announcement, the Treasury Department suspended sanctions on Russian diesel exports until April 7, 2027. Mr. Trump's flip-flop is a lesson for countries such as India, which have been criticised and penalised for trading with Russia. The latest policy switch also exposes the incoherence in western strategic thinking. The West imposed sanctions on Russia's energy sector to weaken Vladimir Putin's "war machine". Four years later, the U.S. began bombing Iran. When the Iran war drove up fuel prices, Washington temporarily eased sanctions on Russian fuel before striking a deal with Moscow.

Beyond the hypocrisy and strategic folly of the U.S. decisions, Mr. Trump's diesel deal also marks the ineffectiveness of the western sanctions regime. When Russia attacked Ukraine in 2022, the West adopted a two-pronged response: weaken the Russian economy through sanctions and weaken the Russian military in Ukraine by arming Kyiv. The sanctions were a double-edged sword, hurting the Russian economy, but the curtailment of trade between Russia and Europe has also plunged European economies, particularly Germany, into deep crises. To offset the impact of the sanctions, Moscow looked east where China and India were willing to buy discounted Russian fuel. The episode also underscores the changes in the economic landscape. Mr. Trump's U-turn leaves Ukraine and Europe in a spot, at a time when Moscow is escalating its bombardment of Ukraine and testing NATO's resolve through grey-zone tactics. If Brussels thinks that prolonging the war would serve its strategic goal of bleeding Russia dry in Ukraine, it may be making a mistake, as Mr. Trump seems less interested in NATO's collective defence or in the defence of Kyiv. Instead, their focus must shift to finding a diplomatic way out. If Mr. Trump can reach a diesel deal with Mr. Putin amid the war, he should work with the warring parties, his allies in Europe and his new partner in Moscow, to secure a ceasefire and ease Russia-NATO tensions. In the meantime, the U.S. and Europe could stop moralising to the Global South for doing trade with Russia.

A contested UNSC seat poses a test for India



Suhasini Haidar

Following the conclusion of the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), held from September 8 to 28, 2026, the government must double its efforts to secure a non-permanent seat on the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) in next year's election. India's bid for the 2028-29 two-year term of the UNSC was launched by External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar this year, with voting in the UN General Assembly (UNGA) to take place in June 2027. As a result, Mr. Jaishankar was busier than usual during UNGA week, holding nearly 90 meetings over a 10-day stay in New York. Between now and next summer, India needs at least 129 affirmative votes in the 193-member Assembly to win.

This has not been as much of an issue on the eight occasions that India has won the seat over the past eight decades, becoming the Asia-Pacific grouping's consensus choice once every decade. Even Pakistan votes for India at the UNGA in these elections, and India returns the favour. With the full backing of the 55-member group, India won a record 187 of 191 votes in 2010 and 184 of 192 votes in 2020.

The bid for a ninth term

India's ambition to win a ninth term is guided by several factors – its terms were in 1950-51, 1967-68, 1972-73, 1977-78, 1984-85, 1991-92, 2011-12 and 2021-22. Its last tenure, in 2021-22, was disrupted by the COVID-19 pandemic, and the Narendra Modi government felt it had been unable to meet all its objectives. New Delhi may want to complete these objectives, including resolutions on terrorism and United Nations reform, before the Modi government's current term ends in 2029. With India's push for permanent membership of the UNSC still elusive, the government may wish to increase the frequency of its non-permanent tenures, keeping India at the centrestage of geopolitics from the UNSC's horseshoe table.

The difference this time, however, is that when India announced its candidacy for the 2027 election, Tajikistan was already in the fray and, according to the chart drawn up for the Asia-Pacific seat, was to be the consensus choice. On the two previous occasions when India had to contest an election – in 1975 against Pakistan and in 1996 against Japan – it lost. Decisions on consensus are made informally by diplomats at the UN, sometimes decades in advance for the 55-country Asia-Pacific grouping.

Like with all the other regional groups – African, Latin American and Caribbean (GRULAC), the Western European and Others Group (WEOG), and the Eastern European Group – a different number of seats fall vacant each year. When consensus breaks down, votes within the group are split, leading to a contest in the wider UNGA. From there it is a race for every country's vote; the rule that contestants must also win two-thirds of the assembly, or more than 129 votes, complicates the task. Given that the course is set, the Modi government has three options, each opening a differently difficult path. The first is to battle it out against Tajikistan on the global stage; the second is to convince the Tajik government to withdraw its candidature; and the third is for India to withdraw its own. Another option – to divide the two-year term equally between the two candidates – has been tried in the past, but these cases have been countries that are evenly matched in other respects.

It is a battle that can be avoided — the path to next year's UNSC election will not be a cakewalk, and India must consider its options

Battling it out

At first glance, India's advantage over Tajikistan seems glaringly obvious, given its size, economic standing and past record on the Council. However, UN insiders know that these are not the only criteria by which UNSC elections are won. To begin with, India's multiple terms on the UNSC may work against it, as there is a growing push within the UNGA to consider smaller countries that have never held council membership such as Tajikistan. In his UNGA speech, Tajik Foreign Minister Sirojiddin Muhriddin said that, more than status, his country's bid for a seat on the UNSC was about its responsibilities to the UN Charter and to "listen to all voices – large and small". This David-versus-Goliath pitch is attractive to other smaller states, especially those from the Global South that feel their lack of representation is unfair. Japan, for instance, which has served 12 terms on the UNSC, announced its candidature for the 2043 election in 2024, having previously declared its intention to contest the 2032 election.

The next important factor is how subregional blocs are likely to vote within the Asia-Pacific grouping. Tajikistan already has the endorsement of its own region, Central Asia, and possibly, by extension, that of several neighbouring countries. It also has the endorsement of the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation, a grouping of 57 member-states which would largely follow that position, although New Delhi may be able to win over some of its friends within the organisation. India is fairly confident of the votes of the Global North – the United States, Canada, Europe, Australia, New Zealand and allied countries – as well as those of Southeast Asian countries (the Association of Southeast Asian Nations or ASEAN), Caribbean nations represented by the Caribbean Community (CARICOM), and Pacific island countries (PIC). This means the battle ground that matters most is the Global South – Africa, South America and also South Asia.

The current mood among Global South countries, as reflected in a number of UNGA resolutions over the past year, has been decidedly against the big powers, the U.S. and Russia, and has been inordinately critical of Israel. During the 80th session, member-states voted overwhelmingly in favour of at least 13 resolutions criticising Israel. The UNSC elections this year were particularly instructive. For the Asia-Pacific seat, the UNGA voted for first-timer Kyrgyzstan over the western-backed Philippines. For the WEOG, Germany, which had never lost a UNSC election, lost to Portugal and Austria, ostensibly due to its stance in support of Israel. In the election for the President of the UNGA, too, the Bangladesh Foreign Minister, Khalilur Rahman, defeated his rival from Cyprus, another western-backed candidate. While India's assertion of strategic autonomy *vis-à-vis* the big powers may stand it in good stead, its diplomats may have to answer questions about India's own ties with Israel in recent years, particularly following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Israel in February 2026.

Tajikistan or India bowing out

The next option, which has worked in the past, is to persuade Tajikistan to withdraw its candidature – India was able to negotiate with Kazakhstan in 2010 for the 2011-12 term, and Afghanistan in 2013 to step aside for the 2021-22 tenure. However, despite meetings between Mr. Modi and Tajik President Emomali Rahmon on the sidelines of the SCO Summit in Bishkek, and between Mr. Jaishankar and his Tajik counterpart during the UNGA session (both in September 2026), there has been no such announcement.

Even if Tajikistan decides to step aside after studying its chances, India must consider the message this would send to other Global South countries: that its second turn in a decade is more important than giving a smaller country its first opportunity to serve on the Council.

This leaves the third alternative, which would certainly make the world sit up: India could agree to step aside for Tajikistan, in order to return to the UNSC a year or two later with the full backing of the Asia-Pacific grouping. Such a move would acknowledge Tajikistan's special strategic relationship with India in the past, particularly its role in hosting an Indian Air Force base at Ayni and a medical base at Farkhor, strategically important in the Afghan conflict in the early part of this century, despite pushback from the U.S., China and even Russia. There is little evidence so far, however, that the Modi government, which announced its candidature with some fanfare, is considering backing down.

The path to securing another non-permanent seat on the UNSC next year is not easy. India's win can only be guaranteed by defeating the ambitions of its old friend and regional partner – the choice is between a Pyrrhic victory versus a tactical defeat. In the bigger war for India's rightful place as a permanent member of the UNSC – one whose voice represents the aspirations of the Global South – this is a battle that could be avoided.

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'Innovate today, nourish tomorrow' for food security

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The simple yet profound theme, "Innovate today, nourish tomorrow", for World Food Day 2026, observed on October 16, reminds us that the future cannot be built with the tools of the past alone. The need to scale up innovation is urgent, as 645 million people still face hunger, while one-third of the world's population cannot afford a healthy diet.

Three interconnected factors continue to push these numbers. Climate-related risks are reducing yields and disrupting growing seasons. Economic shocks and stubborn food-price inflation are eroding purchasing power. Conflict, war and civil strife tear up harvests, displace farmers, disrupt supply chains and destroy the very institutions that protect people from hunger.

From scarcity to surplus and nutrition

Over the decades, India has emerged as a food-surplus nation and one of the world's largest producers of foodgrains, milk, pulses, fruits and vegetables. One of the decisive factors in this transformation from scarcity was the 'Green Revolution'. The introduction of high-yielding varieties, backed by expanded irrigation and assured prices, increased cereal production, which became the basis for India's public distribution and nutrition schemes.

India's abundance in food production has become the foundation of the world's largest food safety net. Under the National Food Security Act, 2013, India provides a legal entitlement to subsidised foodgrains to up to 75% of its rural population and 50% of its urban population, reaching approximately 81 crore people. Since January 2024, the government has provided these foodgrains free of cost under the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana, a guarantee that has been extended until 2028.

This architecture rests on the Targeted Public Distribution System, strengthened by digitised ration cards, Aadhaar seeding and the One Nation One Ration Card portability scheme, which lets migrant workers draw their foodgrain entitlements anywhere in the country.

As countries across the Global South grapple with climate change, conflict and economic uncertainty, India offers lessons that can be adapted to their needs

India's transformation in food security and nutrition is being driven by innovation. The government is focusing on technology, data and finance to make farming more resilient, resource-efficient and viable, while improving access to and the efficiency of food safety nets.

Complementing efforts

It is at this intersection that the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO), the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) and the World Food Programme (WFP) are complementing India's efforts by providing technical expertise, developing solutions and strengthening institutional capacities.

On the farm, the FAO is supporting digital agriculture by developing advisory road maps and building the capacities of frontline extension workers. In livestock and dairy, FAO's Clean Milk Scorecard gives farmers a digital tool to assess cattle management, hygiene and milk production practices and provides actionable feedback. These tools translate technical knowledge into actionable advice, supporting better farm-level decisions and improved productivity. The FAO is also working to address food loss, a challenge with implications for nutrition, resource efficiency, climate action and farmers' incomes. Its work includes measuring losses, assessing their environmental impacts and identifying pathways to valorise them through composting, bioenergy and recycling.

On financing and investment, the IFAD focuses on the first mile of food systems, where risks are highest and private investment is thinnest. Its "financing plus" approach integrates support across the value chain – from production and market access to finance and small-scale infrastructure – and is designed to crowd in domestic public and private capital, rather than substitute for it. Every dollar IFAD has invested in India has leveraged more than three dollars in total investment. Across IFAD's global portfolio, projects with strong private-sector participation have delivered income gains of 64%, four times higher than those without such participation. IFAD is now beginning to lend directly to the private sector to bridge this gap, and India has one of its largest pipelines of such operations in Asia and the Pacific.

On access and availability, the WFP, the world's largest humanitarian organisation and the winner of the 2020 Nobel Peace Prize, has worked in India for over 63 years. It now focuses on enhancing the efficiency of the public food distribution system through innovations such as Grain ATMs, supply chain optimisation and the incubation of solutions through the Public Services Lab at the Indian Institute of Technology Delhi. The WFP also works to improve the nutritional effectiveness of food assistance, particularly for children and pregnant women. This includes assessing food baskets, recommending dietary diversity and integrating nutrition considerations, including the incorporation of nutrient-rich millets and other nutri-cereals.

India's blueprint

India's experience is increasingly relevant beyond its borders. Its innovations have been shaped by constraints, including fragmented landholdings, monsoon-fed agriculture, multilingual populations and limited resources. As nations across the Global South face climate change, conflict and economic uncertainty, India offers principles to adapt.

The future requires us to look beyond sufficiency towards better nutrition, scalable innovations and equitable food systems built around climate-resilient and biofortified crops, nutritionally diverse diets and value chains that reward smallholders. Innovation must remain pro-smallholder and pro-woman, drawing deeply on traditional knowledge even as it embraces scientific advances.

On this World Food Day, we reaffirm our shared resolve with India: to innovate today, and in doing so, to nourish tomorrow.